**Week 10: Subject Organisation of Collections and Indexes (Call Marks)**

## Introduction

In every library, materials must be organised in a systematic and logical manner to enable users to locate and retrieve them easily. This process of arrangement is called **subject organisation**. Subject organisation deals with how library materials are grouped according to their subjects and then arranged on the shelves using **call marks** (also known as **call numbers**).

A call mark uniquely identifies an item's position in the library and indicates what subject area it belongs to. In essence, **subject organisation** and **call marks** are the backbone of effective library arrangement and access.

## Meaning of Subject Organisation

**Subject organisation** refers to the systematic grouping and arrangement of library materials according to the subjects or fields of knowledge they cover.
It ensures that books or other resources on the same or related subjects are shelved together, making it easier for users to find and browse materials on a particular topic.

For example:
In a library using the **Dewey Decimal Classification (DDC)** scheme:

All materials on **Religion** are in the 200s.

All materials on **Technology** are in the 600s.

All materials on **Arts** are in the 700s.

This logical arrangement helps users understand where subjects are located and promotes efficient use of the library collection.

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## Meaning of Call Mark / Call Number

A **call mark** (or **call number**) is the unique identifier placed on a library item (usually on the spine or cover) that indicates both its **subject** and **location** on the shelves.

It acts like an address for the item, showing where it is kept within the library's classification system.

## Example of a Call Mark in DDC:

025.3TAY2018

**025.3** → Classification number (shows the subject: Library cataloguing)

**TAY** → Author's Cutter number (represents the author: Taylor)

**2018** → Year of publication

Hence, this call number shows that the book is on cataloguing, written by Taylor, and published in 2018.

**Components of a Call Mark**

A standard call mark has **three major components**:

**Class Number:**

1. Represents the subject area of the item as assigned by the classification scheme (e.g., 025.3 for cataloguing, 330 for economics).
2. Derived from schemes like DDC, LC, or UDC.

**Author Mark (Cutter Number):**

1. Represents the author or title of the work to differentiate between books on the same subject.
2. Created using **Cutter tables**, e.g., "TAY" for Taylor, "OJO" for Ojo.

**Date of Publication:**

1. Indicates the year of publication and helps to distinguish editions.

**Example:**

808.3ADE2020

This would mean: a book on writing (808.3), authored by Ade, published in 2020.

**Purpose and Importance of Call Marks**

Call marks play a critical role in ensuring the effective organisation and retrieval of library materials.
Some of their major purposes include:

**Identification:** Helps identify each item uniquely.

**Location:** Shows the exact position of an item on the shelf.

**Arrangement:** Ensures logical and systematic arrangement of materials.

**Ease of Access:** Aids users in browsing related materials.

**Inventory Control:** Helps in stock-taking and management.

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Without proper call marks, library shelves would be chaotic, and retrieval of materials would become tedious and confusing.

**How Call Marks Are Assigned**

Assigning a call mark involves several steps:

**Subject Analysis:**

1. Determine the main subject of the material.
2. Identify keywords or concepts that reflect the main focus.

**Select Classification Number:**

Using a classification scheme such as DDC or LC, locate the correct class number that best represents the subject.

**Construct the Author Mark (Cutter Number):**

Apply Cutter tables or use the first letters of the author's surname.

**Add Date of Publication:**

Append the year of publication to the call mark.

**Double-check Consistency:**

Ensure the call mark aligns with the library's existing classification practices.

**Examples from Different Classification Schemes**

**a. DDC (Dewey Decimal Classification):**

641.5JOH2019

– Subject: Cooking (641.5)
– Author: John
– Year: 2019

**b. LC (Library of Congress Classification):**

PN1993.5.N5OKO2016

– Subject: Nigerian Film (PN1993.5.N5)
– Author: Okonkwo
– Year: 2016

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**c. UDC (Universal Decimal Classification):**

37.014.3OGU2021

– Subject: Education management (37.014.3)
– Author: Ogundipe
– Year: 2021

**Subject Indexes and Their Role**

A **subject index** is a tool that lists subjects covered in a collection along with the corresponding call marks or classification numbers.
It helps users to:

1. Find materials on a given subject.
2. Identify related subjects.
3. Access items quickly without browsing the shelves blindly.

**Example:**

| **Subject** | **Call Mark** |
|---|---|
| Cataloguing | 025.3 |
| Library Management | 025.1 |
| Information Literacy | 028 |
| Bibliography | 016 |

Indexes are often found in library catalogues or classification manuals.

**Shelving and Shelf Arrangement**

After assigning call marks, materials are **shelved** according to their sequence.
In DDC and LC systems, arrangement is typically in **numerical and alphabetical order**:

1. First by class number (subject).
2. Then by author mark (alphabetically).
3. Then by year (chronologically).

This logical order allows users to find materials independently.

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**Common Problems in Assigning or Using Call Marks**

**Inconsistency** in applying Cutter numbers.

**Misclassification** due to poor subject analysis.

**Overcrowding** on shelves within popular subjects.

**Fading labels** leading to mis-shelving.

**Human error** in arranging materials.

To overcome these, cataloguers must ensure accuracy, maintain shelf discipline, and update call marks where necessary.

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